FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

I have always considered Naveen Patnaik to be one of the miracles of Indian politics. Although his father Biju Patnaik, the legendary former chief minister of Odisha, was a towering political personality, Naveen had no interest in politics. He was engaged more in writing books, travelling abroad and rubbing shoulders with the international jet set—the likes of Jacqueline Kennedy Onassis and rock-star Mick Jagger. Having attended elite schools, he had led a life of privilege, far from the heat and dust of politics. It was, therefore, a surprise when he agreed to don his father's mantle after he passed away in 1997. He seemed too westernised to really master the machinations of Odisha politics. To top it all, he knew only a smattering of the local language. So, when Naveen took over as chief minister in March 2000 as a 53-year-old freshman, he seemed doomed to failure. Miraculously, 24 years later, he is not only still around but is also on the cusp of electoral greatness. A five-time chief minister already, he hopes to break all records by winning a sixth consecutive term for his party, the Biju Janata Dal (BJD), and himself. If he pulls it off, Naveen will be on course to become the longest-serving chief minister India has ever seen by August, overtaking Pawan Chamling's record of 24 years and 165 days in Sikkim. Conversely, if he falls short, the 2024 election will probably be the last the 77-year-old will contest. So, Naveen stands on the brink of making history or being history.



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It is, without doubt, the fiercest electoral battle Naveen has ever fought. Odisha is hosting simultaneous polls for its 21 Lok Sabha constituencies and 147 assembly seats. The dynamics that operate on the two planes are different, even if entirely intertwined. Mainly because the prime contenders are the same: Naveen's BJD is going head-to-head with the formidable Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who is also widely popular in the state. In their first title bout in 2014, Naveen had won hands down, with the BJD securing a landslide in the assembly election and winning 20 out of the 21 Lok Sabha seats despite a Modi wave in that election. But in 2019, Naveen began to feel the heat as the BJP made deep inroads into Odisha and emerged as the BJD's prime challenger, pushing aside the Congress. Naveen did retain the assembly by a two-thirds majority. But the BJP won eight out of the 21 parliamentary seats, its vote share climbing to 38 per cent, just five percentage points short of the BJD. The gap was more significant in the assembly—but the BJP secured 32 per cent to the BJD's 45 per cent, entrenching itself in the landscape.

For Election 2024, Naveen is essentially letting his track record speak for itself and running with a positive agenda. The BJP, by contrast, is focusing on attacking him personally about his failing health and unsubstantiated rumours of dire medical conditions that render him unsuitable for high office. Naveen may not show himself publicly or interact with other politicians as most other chief ministers do, but he has had plenty of successes to showcase in his 24 years in power. Odisha was among India's poorest states when he took charge, with 63.8 per cent of the population falling below the poverty line even in 2006. Today, that figure stands at 11.07 per cent—perhaps the sharpest fall in poverty anywhere in India. Odisha's current per capita income of Rs 1.6 lakh is higher than that of other backward states like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal and Jharkhand. Its GDP growth was an impressive 7.8 per cent last year, higher than the national average of 7 per cent. Odisha is also the rare Indian state that's fiscally well managed, with a debt-to-GDP ratio of 13.1, the lowest in the country. It has a revenue surplus of Rs 43,471 crore, much of it flowing from policy changes that cleared auctioning of its vast mining resources—the process, beginning in 2019, that saw revenues grow five-fold.

That cash reserve has enabled Naveen to spend massive amounts on welfare programmes, including introducing digital blackboards across state high schools and building state-of-the-art sports facilities. Indeed, Odisha has now become a hub of national and international hockey—it's encouraging youth to take to sports in a big way. Naveen has also focused on revamping hospitals and introduced a healthcare scheme called Biju Swasthya Kalyan Yojana (BKSY) that goes beyond the Centre's insurance-based Ayushman Bharat. The BKSY provides Odia citizens with free treatment of up to Rs 5 lakh per person in the best private health facilities using a card: the state government pays the hospitals directly. Regarding women's empowerment, Naveen is among the most progressive CMs, having introduced 50 per cent reservations for women in panchayati raj institutions in 2011. He followed it up in 2018 by reserving 33 per cent of the Lok Sabha candidacies for women, a rule he enforced in 2019 and in the current election. On the ground, his Mission Shakti scheme to encourage women entrepreneurs through self-help groups has transformed the lives of over seven million women.

All these successes were possible because of Naveen's no-nonsense, keep-it-simple, minimum speeches and maximum governance approach. He stayed put in Odisha and focused on his state's development, rarely travelling to Delhi or abroad and mainly relying on key bureaucrats to execute his vision while keeping a tight leash on his party leaders. The BJP is projecting these unique strengths as his biggest weakness. The party alleges that non-Odia IAS officers are running the state and that he is just an effete, forgetful figurehead. Much of the criticism is directed towards V. Karthikeya Pandian, his former private secretary, who resigned from the IAS in October 2023, joined the BJD, and was appointed chairman of the states powerful '5T' programme, with cabinet rank status. Even Modi indirectly criticised Pandian's role at a recent election rally, saying, "In Odisha, there is a SuperCM who lords over the democratically elected CM and MLAs." The BJP has made restoring Odia "*asmita*" (pride) its prime election plank and has pledged to stop "outsiders" like Pandian, who is of Tamil origin, from controlling the state. Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa visited Odisha to understand how this crucial battle unfolded. The electoral war for the state has intensified as Prime Minister Modi has declared that the BJP will be forming the next state government and is also pushing aggressively to multiply its Lok Sabha tally. What makes it most interesting is that the fight is between two highly popular leaders—one national and the other local.



(Aroon Purie)